

2 THESSALONIANS

THE SECOND

EPISTLE OF S. PAUL, THE APOSTLE,

TO THE THESSALONIANS.

PREFACE.

In this epistle S. Paul admonishes the Thessalonians to be constant in the faith of Christ, and not to be terrified by the insinuations of false teachers, telling them that the day of judgment was near at hand, as there must come many signs and wonders before it. He bids them to hold firm the traditions received from him, whether by word or by epistle; and shews them how they may be certain of his letters by the manner he writes. This epistle was written soon after the former, and also from Corinth, about A. 52. Ch. Wi. — From the context we learn that the present is a continuation of the former epistle. He not only rectifies wrong impressions caused by his former letter, but finding that those indolent characters whom he had reprimanded were no ways corrected, he determines to reprimand them still more severely in this letter, which he tells us he writes because he has it not in his power to visit, as he could wish, the Thessalonians.

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2 THESSALONIANS 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 5. For an example of the just judgment of God. That is, that the persecutions and troubles you suffer in this world shew the justice of God in punishing men for their sins, even in this life, so that by these temporal pains you may be found worthy of a crown of eternal glory in the kingdom of God.

Wi. — The afflictions, which are here frequently the portion of the just, are sensible proofs of the rigour with which the Almighty will, at the day of final retribution, pour out his indignation on the wicked. For, if he is unwilling to let the just be free from all temporal punishment, (though he discharges their debt of the eternal) and if he continually exposes them to the derision, calumnies, and persecutions of the wicked, what have not the wicked to apprehend when he shall stretch forth his hand in vengeance? Or, as others explain it, God permits the good to be persecuted here, that one day he may treat the wicked according to the rigour of his justice. He permits them here to fill up the measure of their iniquities, that on the last day he may reward the long suffering of the one, and punish the infidelity of the other. In both the one and the other, the finger of God's justice will clearly manifest itself. If the hopes of the good reached no farther than this life, they would be the most wretched of beings; for here, in general, they are more exposed than any to the injuries of the wicked. Nothing proves more clearly the necessity of a general judgment, than this his conduct to his most chosen servants. For it is impossible that, just as he is, he should permit patience and faith to go unrewarded, or wickedness and injustice unpunished. The Son of God has promised us heaven only on condition that we bear wrongs patiently. Calmet. — Here again the apostle teaches the advantages of sufferings which the Thessalonians joyfully underwent, to be counted worthy of the kingdom of God, *Kataxiiothenai umas*; and v. 11, *ibid. axiose*. The apostle teaches here, that nothing defiled shall ever enter into the kingdom of heaven; and gives us to understand at the same time, that he will one day punish with extreme rigour the cruelty and impiety of persecutors. V.

Ver. 6. Seeing[1] it is a just thing. Lit. If yet it be just. S. Chrys. takes notice, that we must not expound the text as if S. Paul made a doubt whether it was just or not for God to repay retribution to such as troubled, afflicted, and persecuted his faithful servants, and to punish them when he shall be revealed (i.e. at the day of judgment) with flaming fire, or with the flames of hell: nothing certainly is more just; as on the contrary, it is just to reward the pious and those who are found worthy of the glorious kingdom of God. Wi.

Ver. 9. Being confounded with the face of the Lord, whom they have rejected, and with the glory of his power and greatness, which will appear in irresistible splendour and majesty.

Ver. 10. This shall be at the last day, when Christ shall come to be glorified in his saints, and to be made[2] wonderful (to be admired and praised) in or by all them who have believed in that day: (i.e. the things foretold of that day) because our testimony[3] was believed upon you concerning that day, i.e. as to the punishments and rewards that shall be given on that day. Wi.

Ver. 11. Wherefore, also we pray, &c. By the Greek, the sense and construction cannot be in, or on which day; and therefore it must be referred to what was said before, that God should be glorified in his saints, and so may be translated, on which[4] account we pray, &c. that Christ may be glorified in you, being made saints by his grace, &c. Wi.

Ver. 12. That the name of our Lord, &c. The name of God is glorified by the virtuous lives of Christians, but more especially by that constancy and firmness evinced by the faithful under the hands of the executioner. It is an act of the most perfect charity, to lay down our lives in defence of his truths and the glory of his name, and the most disinterested testimony of our allegiance to him. Nothing appeared more admirable than the constancy of the first Christians, and nothing contributed more to the conversion of the Gentiles than the firmness with which they maintained, even in death, the truths that had been taught them. For, said they, this religion is certainly true, since there is nothing they are not willing to suffer in defence of it. Calmet. — And you in him, &c. If Christians are any way instrumental in procuring the glory of God, let them not attribute it to themselves, but to God alone, from whom comes every gift. If they procure his glory before men, he at the day of final retribution will clothe them with never-fading robes of immortality, in the presence of men and Angels. If it be glorious for God to be adored by such faithful servants, it is much more glorious for Christians to be rewarded by such a Master: for it is the glory of a servant to be faithful to his master, and the glory of the master to recompense his servant. Est. Grot. Theophylact. &c.

[1] V. 6. Si tamem justum est, eiper dikaion. See S. Chrys. (log. b. p. 226) eiper entautha anti tou epei, &c.

[2] V. 10. Admirabilis fieri in omnibus, thaumasthenai en pasi.

[3] Ibid. Quia creditum est testimonium nostrum super vos in illa die, oti episteuthe to marturion emon eph umas, en te emera ekeine.

[4] V. 11. In quo, eis o, in quod, but it cannot agree with emera, day.

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2 THESSALONIANS 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. And we, &c. Some impostors had taken occasion from S. Paul's first epistle to the Thessalonians, to teach that the day of judgment was at hand.

The apostle here maintains that it certainly will come, but that it will come like a thief in the night. He says nothing of the time when it is to arrive; he merely refutes those who spoke of its taking place immediately. — By the coming, &c.

Grotius and some others explain this coming, of the vengeance he took on the Jews by the arms of the Romans. It is true he speaks in many places of the destruction of Jerusalem, and of his coming at the last day, in terms exactly the same. But the context of the whole epistle demonstrates that he is here speaking of the last day. Calmet. — And of our gathering together[1] unto him.

Lit. of our congregation unto him. That is, that you be not moved by any pretended revelation, nor by any words or letter, as spoken or written by me.

Wi.

Ver. 2. S. Austin, writing to Hesychium, declareth that no one from the Scripture can be assured of the day, year, or age when the second coming shall be. ep. lxxx. Let us attend to what S. Austin declares he had learnt from the first Church authorities. At the last judgment, or about that time, will arrive Elias, the Thesbite, the conversion of the Jews, the persecution of antichrist, the coming of Jesus Christ, the resurrection of the dead, the separation of the good from the bad, the conflagration of the world, and the renovation of the same: that these things will arrive, we are to believe, but in what manner and in what order experience will teach better than reason. It is my opinion that they will come in the order I have related them. De. Civ. Dei. lib. xx. cap. ult. That the man of sin will be born of the Jewish tribe of Dan, that he will cruelly persecute the faithful for three years and a half, that he will put to death Henech and Elias, and that great, very great, will be the apostacy, is the general belief. Oh!

God, preserve us with thy grace, and do not permit us to lose sight of the dreadful danger that threatens even the elect.

Ver. 3-4. First, &c.[2] What is meant by this falling away, (in the Greek this apostacy) is uncertain, and differently expounded. S. Jerom and others understand it of a falling off of other kingdoms, which before were subject to the Roman empire; as if S. Paul said to them: you need not fear that the day of judgment is at hand, for it will not come till other kingdoms, by a general revolt, shall have fallen off, so that the Roman empire be destroyed. The same interpreters expound the sixth and seventh verses in like manner, as if when it is said, now you know[3] what withholdeth, &c. That is, you see the Roman empire subsisteth yet, which must be first destroyed. And when it is added, only that he who now holdeth, do hold, until he be taken out of the way; the sense, say these authors, is, let Nero and his successors hold that empire till it be destroyed, for not till then will the day of judgment come. A. Lapide makes this exposition so certain, that he calls it a tradition of the fathers, which to him seems apostolical. But we must not take the opinion of some fathers, in the exposition of obscure prophecies, where they advance conjectures (which others at the same time reject, or doubt of) to be apostolical traditions, and articles of

faith, as the learned bishop of Meaux, Bossuet, takes notice on this very subject, in his preface and treatise on the Apocalypse, against Jurieux. S.

Jerom indeed, and others, thought that the Roman empire was to subsist till the antichrist's coming, which by the event most interpreters conclude to be a mistake, and that it cannot be said the Roman empire continues to this time.

See Lyranus on this place, S. Tho. Aquin. Salmeron, Estius, and many others; though A. Lapide, with some few, pretend the Roman empire still subsists in the emperors of Germany. We also find that divers of the ancient fathers thought that the day of judgment was just at hand in their time. See Tertul. S.

Cyp. S. Greg. the Great, &c. And as to this place, it cannot be said the fathers unanimously agree in their exposition. S. Chrys.[4] Theodoret, S. Aug. in one of his expositions, by this falling off, and apostacy, understand antichrist himself, apostatizing from the Catholic faith. And they who expound it of Nero, did not reflect that this letter of S. Paul was written under Claudius, before Nero's reign. According to a third and common exposition, by this revolt or apostacy, others understand a great falling off of great numbers from the Catholic Church and faith, in those nations where it was professed before; not but that, as S. Aug. expressly takes notice, the Church will remain always visible, and Catholic in its belief, till the end of the world. This interpretation we find in S. Cyr.[5] of Jerusalem. Catech. 15. See also S. Anselm on this place, S. Thomas, Salmeron, Estius, &c. In fine, that there is no apostolical tradition, as to any of the interpretations of these words, we may be fully convinced from the words of S. Aug.[6] l. xx. de Civ. Dei. c. 19. t. 7. p. 597. Nov. edit. where he says: For my part, I own myself altogether ignorant what the apostle means by these words; but I shall mention the suspicions of others, which I have read, or heard. Then he sets down the exposition concerning the Roman empire. He there calls that a suspicion and conjecture, which others say is an apostolical tradition. In like manner the ancient fathers are divided, as to the exposition of the words of the sixth and seventh verse, when it is

said you know what hindereth; some understand that antichrist must come first. Others, that the beforementioned apostacy, or falling off from the Church, must happen before. And when S. Paul says, (v. 7.) that he who now holdeth, do hold; some expound it, let him take care at the time of such trials, to hold, and preserve the true faith to the end. When the expositions are so different, as in this place, whosoever pretends to give a literal translation ought never to add words to the text, which determine the sense to such a particular exposition, and especially in the same print, as Mr. N. hath done on the seventh verse, where he translates, only let him that now holdeth the faith, keep it until he be taken out of the way. — And the man of sin^[7] revealed, the son of perdition, so that he sitteth in the temple of God, shewing himself as if he were God. He is called again, (v. 8.) that wicked one . . . whom the Lord Jesus Christ shall kill with the spirit of his mouth. By all these words is described to us the great antichrist, about the end of the world, according to the unexceptionable authority and consent of the ancient fathers. It is as ridiculous as malicious to pretend, with divers later reformers, that the pope, and all the popes since the destruction of the Roman empire, are the great antichrist, the man of sin, &c.

Grotius, Dr. Hammond, and divers learned Protestants, have confuted and ridiculed this groundless fable, of which more on the Apocalypse. It may suffice to observe here that antichrist, the man of sin, the son of perdition, the wicked one, according to all the ancients, is to be one particular man, not so many different men. That he is to come a little while before the day of judgment. That he will make himself be adored, and pretend to be God. What pope did so? That he will pretend to be Christ, &c. Wi. — S. Aug. (de Civ. Dei.

b. xx. c. 19.) says, that an attack would be made at one and the same time against the Roman empire and the Church. The Roman empire subsists as yet, in Germany, though much weakened and reduced. The Roman Catholic Church, notwithstanding all its losses, and the apostacy of many of its children, has always remained the same. Calmet. — The two special signs of the last day will be a general revolt, and the manifestation of antichrist, both of which are so dependent on each other, that S. Austin makes but one of both.

What presumptive folly in Calvin and other modern reformers, to oppose the universal sentiments of the fathers both of the Latin and Greek Church! What inconsistency, to give such forced interpretations, not only widely different from the expositions of sound antiquity, but also widely different from each other! The Church of God, with her head, strong in the promises of Jesus Christ, will persevere to the end, frustra circumlatrantibus hæreticis. Aug. de util. cred. c. xvii. — In the temple. Either that of Jerusalem, which some think he will rebuild; or in some Christian Church, which he will pervert to his own worship; as Mahomet has done with the churches of the east. Ch.

Ver. 7. The mystery of iniquity already worketh,[8] or is now wrought, by the precursors of antichrist; i.e. by infidels and heretics. For, as S. John says, there are many antichrists, precursors to the great antichrist, and enemies of Christ. 1 John c. ii. Wi. — That he who now holdeth, do hold. That is, let each one remain in the faith which he has received of us, and let him not permit himself to be deceived by any discourse, as coming from us. Or rather, let those who shall then be in the world keep their faith, remaining firm in their belief and attachment to the Church of Christ, until antichrist, that man of iniquity, shall be taken away. Calmet. — According to others, it is an admonition to the faithful not to be beguiled during this day of trial by such, as under the garb of religion, and with an ostentatious parade of zeal for the holy Scriptures, seek to deceive them. When the mystery of sin shall be revealed, then shall we plainly discover that apostacy from the Catholic Church is the obvious and certain road to a dereliction of all religious principle; yes, to antichristianism and to atheism. A.

Ver. 8. Spirit of his mouth, &c. S. Paul makes use of this expression, to shew the ease with which God can put down the most powerful from his seat. He does it likewise to give the Thessalonians a right notion of the man of sin. For as he before told them, he would cause himself to be adored, they might have imagined him more upon an equality with the Almighty. These words, however, quite take away that meaning. He shall strike the earth with the rod of his mouth, and with the breath of his lips he shall slay the wicked. Isai. xi. 4. &c.

Calmet.

Ver. 10. God shall send them the operation of error.[9] That is, says S. Chrys.

and S. Cyril, he will permit them to be led away with illusions, by signs, and lying prodigies, which the devil shall work by antichrist, &c. Wi. — God shall suffer them to be deceived by lying wonders, and false miracles, in punishment of their not entertaining the love of truth. Ch. — The end God proposes is the judgment and condemnation of such as reject the proffered light. This is the march of sin, according to S. Tho. Aquin. on this place. In the first place a man, in consequence of his first sin, is deprived of grace, he then falls into further sins, and ends with being eternally punished. Hence it happens that his new sins are a punishment of his former transgressions; because God will permit the devil to do these things. Deus mittet, quia Deus Diabolum facere ista permittet. S. Aug. lib. xx. de Civ. Dei. c. 19.

Ver. 12. That God hath chosen you first-fruits. Called you the first, or before many others, by his eternal decree, to the faith, whilst he hath left others in darkness and infidelity. Wi.

Ver. 14. Traditions, . . . whether by word,[10] or by our epistle. Therefore, says S. Chrys. the apostle did not deliver all things that were to be believed, by writing; (Wi.) but many things by word of mouth only, which have been perpetuated by tradition, and these traditions, no less than the writings of the apostles, are deserving of faith. Omoios de kakeina, kai tauta estin axiopista.

S. Chrysos. hic.

[1] V. 1. Et nostræ congregationis in ipsum, kai emon episunagoges ep auton.

[2] V. 3-4. Nisi venerit discessio primum, e apostasia. S. Hier. (Ep. ad Algasiam.

q. 11. t. 4. p. 209) Apostasia, inquit [] ut omnes Gentes, quæ Rom. Imperio subjacent, recedant ab eis.

[3] Ibid. S. Chrys. (log. d. p. 235) says that by these words, you know what hindereth, is probably understood the Roman empire, &c. and Tertull. (l. de Resur. Carnis. c. xxiv. p. 340) on those words, till taken out of the way, donec de medio fiat, Quis nisi Romanorum status?

[4] Ibid. S. Chrys. (log. g. p. 232) ti estin e apostasia autoi kalei ton Antichriston. See Theodoret on this place.

[5] Ibid. S. Cyr. of Jerusalem (Cat. xv) says, this apostacy is from the true faith and good works: aute estin e apostasia. S. Anselm and others mention both expositions, i.e. from the Roman empire, or from the faith.

[6] Ibid. S. Aug. Ego prorsus quid dixerit, me fateor ignorare . . . suspiciones tamen hominum, quas vel audire, vel legere potui, non tacebo, &c. Quidam putant hoc de Imperio dictum esse Romano, &c.

[7] Ibid. O anthropos tes amartias, o uios tes apoleias, o antikeimenos, &c. ille homo peccati, ille filius perditionis: the Greek articles sufficiently denote a particular man.

[8] V. 7. Mysterium jam operatur iniquitatis, to musterion ede energeitai.

[9] V. 10. Mittet illis Deus operationem erroris, pempsei, &c. S. Cyr. Hier. Cat. 5.

sunchorei ginesthai. See also S. Chrys. log. d. p. 236.

[10] V. 14. S. Chrys. 237. enteuthen deilon, &c.

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2 THESSALONIANS 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. May run. That is, may spread itself, and have free course. Ch.

Ver. 2. From troublesome, or importunate men. In the Greek, is signified men who act unreasonably, absurdly, &c. Wi. — For all men have not faith. Faith is a gift of God, which he is not obliged to give but to whom he will. S. Paul here assures us that he finds nothing but obstacles in his great work, nothing but enemies of the truth, and nothing but men who resist the inspirations and calls of God, opposing the preaching of the gospel. He exhorts them not to be scandalized at what they see him suffer, but to return thanks to God, who has vouchsafed to call them, giving them an understanding and docile heart.

Calmet.

Ver. 3. From evil. It may either signify evil things, or the evil one, the devil. Wi.

Ver. 5. Or, according to the Greek, may the Lord direct and carry your hearts to the love of God, and to the expectation of Jesus Christ.

Ver. 6. Charge, or declare; or by the Greek, we command. — In the name of our Lord. This may signify a separation by excommunication. Wi. — That you withdraw, &c. S. Chrysostom upon this place, S. Austin, Theophylactus, and others understand S. Paul as speaking of a kind of excommunication. But S.

Chrys. on v. 13. and 14. seems to restrain its meaning to a prohibition for the guilty to speak to any body, unless they spoke to him, if their conversation tended to exhort him to repentance. Theophylactus likewise remarks that this punishment was formerly much dreaded, though now not in use.

Ver. 8. Burthensome. By the Greek, he understands those who being idle, and not keeping themselves employed, lead a disorderly life. Wi.

Ver. 9. If I, to whom you are indebted for the preaching of the gospel, have yielded my claims, unwilling to receive any thing from you, and

even labouring with my own hands for the necessities of life, how are those to be borne with who do nothing, and yet will be supported at another's expense? for S. Paul had witnessed amongst them some of this idle disposition. Estius.

Ver. 10. Not work. By prying with curiosity into other men's actions. He that is idle, saith S. Chrys. will be given to curiosity. Wi. — The apostles, like our Lord, were fond of introducing popular saying or axioms. Another, and not unlike the former, is found in one of the Jewish rabbies, Zeror: Qui non laboraverit in Prosabbato, nè edat in Sabbato.

Ver. 12. Eat their own bread, which they work for, and deserve, not that of others. Wi.

Ver. 14. Here the apostle teaches that our pastors must be obeyed, and not only secular princes; and with respect to such as will not be obedient to their spiritual governors, the apostle, (as S. Austin affirmeth) ordains that they be corrected by admonition, by degradation, or excommunication. Cont. Donat.

post Callat. c. iv. 20. & l. de correptione & grat. c. iii.

Ver. 15. Do not regard him as an enemy. A necessary introduction for those whom Providence has placed over others, to admonish and correct them, but with charity and peace; so that we neither be, nor give them occasion to think we are their enemies. Wi. — He is your brother; compassionate his weakness; he is a sick member of the same body of which you are one of the members; the greater his infirmity, the greater should be your charity and anxiety for his cure; the greater excommunication separated the delinquent from the communion of the Church, making him in our regard as a heathen or a publican. But he is not here speaking of this kind, for he allows the faithful to speak to him for his spiritual advantage. Calmet.

Ver. 17. The salvation of, &c. The apostle gives them this caution, for fear the faithful might be deceived by fictitious letters. For they had already received one of this kind, which had terrified them, by

foretelling that the day of judgment was at hand. This deception he is here anxious to remove, signing the present communication with his own hand, and sealing it with his own seal. For although the rest of the epistle had been written by another, these words to the end were written by himself. Estius. — All the civilities of this great doctor of grace terminate in wishing it to his friends. This is his genuine character, because it is the love and continual effusion of his heart. V.

Amen. This the congregation added after the epistle had been read, and from this circumstance alone has it found a place here. Polus synopsis Criticorum, p. 1003, vol. 4.

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